Session 1: The Debt

Overview

The heist party (Zan, Aurora, Bardolemeu, Kaelyn, Balor) has been summoned by FX to a safe house in the frontier town of **Stonefall**. He's rattled. He found something in the Thormvuld documents -- a strange symbol and references to a facility called **Site Gamma-7**. He wants the party to investigate it. During the briefing, **Nyra** and **Aegon** arrive separately, each drawn by their own connection to the mystery.

Session goal: Establish the party, give them a reason to stay together, set the hook for Site Gamma-7.

Party composition: Zan, Aurora, Bardolemeu, Kaelyn, Balor, Nyra, Aegon (7 players) **Absent:** Odessa, Sanzo

Target runtime: 4 hours.

PART 1: ARRIVAL AND SETTLING IN (30-45 min)

The session opens with each heist-party member arriving at the safe house **separately, over the past two days**. They've all been here for 12-48 hours. They've had awkward meals together, claimed bedrooms, and generally avoided each other.

Start in media res: It's late afternoon. The party is scattered around the compound. Some are in their rooms. Some are in the courtyard. Bardolemeu might be in the common room tuning his lute. Kaelyn might be outside, watching the frontier. Balor might be sharpening his blade in a corner. Aurora might be on the roof, looking at the sky. Zan might be checking all the exits.

Your opening line: "*You've been at the safe house for a day or two now. Long enough to claim a bed, learn the creaky floorboards, and memorize the dinner rotation. FX hasn't called you together yet -- he's been locked in his office with those Thormvuld documents. The compound has high walls, two hired guards who keep to themselves, and a well in the courtyard. Beyond the gate: Stonefall. A frontier town that doesn't ask questions -- but watches closely.*"

Conversation Starters (Drop These In If the Table Goes Quiet)

Use these to nudge players into character interactions:

- **To anyone in the common room:** "*FX's cook made stew again. It's edible. The bread is hard. Someone mentions there's a tavern in town that serves actual ale.*"

- **To anyone in the courtyard:** "*The sun is setting over the frontier. It's beautiful in a desolate way -- orange and purple over endless grass and scattered ruins.*"
- **To Bardolemeu:** "*The old lute in your hands -- your mentor's instrument -- has a small compartment in the body you never noticed before. You found it this morning while re-stringing. Inside: a folded piece of paper with a strange mark, and one word: 'Remember.'*" [GM note: This plants his connection to the symbol without revealing it yet -- he hasn't seen FX's symbol, so he doesn't know they're connected.]
- **To Balor:** "*Khar'zul has been quiet. Too quiet. The blade hasn't whispered since you arrived in Stonefall. It's almost unsettling. You find yourself checking if it's still there.*"
- **To Aurora:** "*The stars are beginning to appear. One of your hidden constellations -- the Broken Crown -- is visible tonight, low on the horizon, pulsing faintly. It points toward the frontier.*"
- **To Kaelyn:** "*Your crystal heart has been warm since you arrived. Not painful -- just present. Like it's listening to something in the distance.*"
- **To Zan:** "*The compound is secure. Two exits, three if you count the root cellar. The guards are amateurs. You could leave unseen whenever you wanted. But something keeps you here.*"

Stonefall Mini-Sandbox (Optional Exploration)

Some players might want to stretch their legs. The safe house gate is not locked from the inside. Here are the interesting spots in town:

The Market Square (15 min):

- Open-air trading post at the town's center
- A **town crier** announces: "*Word from the east! House Thormvuld offers a reward for information on a theft from their estate! No names given -- but descriptions match persons last seen heading west. Citizens are encouraged to report any suspicious activity!*"
- A merchant sells frontier maps. One mentions: "*Strange lights near an old ruin, three days west. Probably nothing. Probably.*"
- A wanted poster on a board: rough sketches of two party members (whoever was most visible during the heist -- Zan and Kaelyn if they were extraction party faces, or whoever makes sense). The sketches are inexact but close enough to be unsettling. The poster offers a reward for "information leading to recovery of stolen property" -- no names.
- The party might buy supplies, hear rumors, or feel the weight of being hunted.

The Shrine of Aurelius (10 min):

- Small, well-maintained stone shrine. Cleric: **Old Man Rourke**, a one-armed veteran who lost his arm to a griffon 40 years ago.

- He offers blessings and basic healing (if anyone asks). He's chatty: "*You're staying at the old mercenary compound? That's FX's place now, ain't it? He pays well, keeps to himself. Smart man, building a wall before the monsters come knocking.*"
- If Aegon visits: Rourke notices his holy symbol. "*A paladin of the Scales. Rare to see your kind this far out. Most stay in the capitals, chasing politics. Good to see someone still walks the frontier.*" A subtle reminder that Aegon's order is distant.

The Rusty Compass Tavern (15 min):

- Stonefall's most popular tavern. Warm, noisy, frontier charm.
- Bardolemeu could perform for a few copper and a free drink. The crowd is rough but appreciative.
- A half-drunk trapper mutters: "*Wolves've been acting strange lately. Saw a pack yesterday carrying shiny rocks in their mouths like pups with toys. Never seen that before.*" [Extremely subtle hoarding instinct hint -- dismissed as a drunk's rambling.]
- A stranger watches the party from a dark corner. If approached, they're just a traveling merchant nursing an ale. If the party is paranoid (they should be), this builds tension. The stranger is nobody. But they don't know that.

PART 2: FX'S BRIEFING (15-20 min)

The Call

As evening falls, FX emerges from his office. He calls the party into the common room. Lamplight. Fire in the hearth. He's holding a folder. He looks tired -- not his usual polished self.

What FX Says

"*I've been through everything you brought me from Seidga'ard. Every document. Every schematic. Every note. Took me days to decode the encryption. The Thormvulds are thorough -- I'll give them that.*"

[He sets the folder on the table. Opens it. Inside: a paper with the symbol drawn on it.]

"*But beneath the encryption, buried in the internal memos, I found references to something called the* ***Weave-Stabilization Initiative****. It mentions a facility:* ***Site Gamma-7****. And every document referencing it is stamped with this mark.*"

[FX taps the symbol -- a circle with three sweeping curves, one broken.]

*"I've been asking around. Quietly. One contact recognized it -- said it belongs to a group called the **Arquitetos** -- 'Architects.' That's all he knew. They operated decades ago. Research of some kind. The trail goes cold after that."*

*"What concerns me is this: the Thormvulds were **using their methods**. The experiments in that underground lab? The way they handled the crystals? It wasn't Thormvuld original research. They were **copying someone else's work**."*

[FX pauses. Looks at each of them.]

"And since the heist, I've had reports of people asking questions. Not Thormvuld -- I know their network. Different questions. About the crystals. About 'who took them.' The mark keeps coming up."

"I want you to find Site Gamma-7. It's three days into the frontier -- an abandoned research outpost. Bring back anything you can find. Records. Equipment. Anything that tells me who these Architects were and what they were doing. I need to know if we stepped into something bigger than a heist."

What FX Does NOT Say

- He's scared. Not of the Thormvulds -- of what this symbol might mean.
- He knows the name "Flesh Architects" but hasn't found anything solid on them.
- He's considering cutting ties and disappearing if this is too big.
- The symbol has been nagging at him in ways he can't explain.

The Symbol Recognition Beat

After FX reveals the symbol, pause. Give the table a moment. The three players who received private tells can now choose to speak up or stay silent.

Do not prompt them. Let the silence hang. If no one speaks, FX continues. The recognition is theirs to reveal or hide.

PART 3: NYRA ARRIVES (10 min)

Mid-briefing. A knock at the gate. FX's guard: *"Boss, someone's here. Says she needs to talk. She's got a mark -- like the one on your papers."*

Her Entrance

Nyra enters. She's young, practical frontier gear, pale blue-grey skin. She carries a quarterstaff topped with a pale blue crystal. She's wary but purposeful.

She produces her parents' locked box and shows the **two-curve mark** on its underside.

"*An antiquities dealer told me you've been asking about marks like this one. I've had this box since I was eighteen. It belonged to my parents -- before they disappeared. This mark is the only clue I have.*"

FX lays his symbol next to her mark. They're clearly related -- same style, same origin -- but hers is missing a curve.

"*Yours is missing a piece. Or mine has an extra. Either way, someone's been leaving marks. And we're both finding them.*"

Why Nyra Stays

- Her locked box might be connected to FX's mystery
- FX offers resources and protection
- She needs help finding three more elemental crystals -- a party of seven is better than alone
- Site Gamma-7 is in the frontier -- it's on the way to where her leads point

PART 4: AEGON ARRIVES (10 min)

Shortly after Nyra settles. Another disturbance at the gate. This time, a guard sounds more tense: "*Boss... there's a paladin outside. Just standing there. Won't say what he wants.*"

His Entrance

Aegon is brought in. Armed. Armored. Suspicious. He studies the room before speaking.

"*My name is Aegon. I'm a paladin of the Order of the Scales. And I've been dreaming of a place -- a ruin with a broken tower and a collapsed dome. A merchant told me it's called Site Gamma-7. I came here to find someone who knows the way.*"

FX goes quiet. He pulls out the folder with the symbol. Aegon studies it.

"*I haven't seen this mark before. But the place I saw in my dreams... that's your facility.*"

Why Aegon Stays

- His vision led him here, to these people
- FX's mystery and his vision are connected

- The Order would not approve of him chasing dreams into the frontier -- but he follows his own path

PART 5: THE DECISION (15-20 min)

FX leans back. Looks at the assembled group.

"*I need people I can trust for this. Are you in?*"

What FX Provides

- A hand-drawn map to Site Gamma-7 (rough but serviceable)
- Provisions for 7 people, 5 days (dried food, water, camping gear)
- A pouch of gold for expenses
- One sending stone, paired with his own -- for emergencies only
- A warning: "*This is three days into monster territory. Stay sharp. Stay hidden. I don't know what's in that facility. But whoever built it was careful to bury it.*"

Potential Hesitations

If anyone hesitates, the table can roleplay through it. FX can add incentives (future payment, safe house access, protection from Thormvuld). Other party members can make their case. This is the session's emotional core -- the moment they choose to be a party.

All Player Motivations (For Your Reference)

PC	Why They Say Yes
Zan	Vague memory of the symbol from the Flesh Architects. Needs to know.
Aurora	The symbol matches her constellation. The stars are pointing to Gamma-7.
Bardolemeu	Nowhere else to go (Thormvuld bounty). Practicality + curiosity.
Kaelyn	Twenty years staring at that symbol in prison. She needs answers.
Balor	The frontier is where his mother's cache is. Gamma-7 is on the way.
Nyra	Her mark and FX's mark are connected. This is about her parents.
Aegon	The vision told him to go. He trusts his visions more than anything.

PART 6: DEPARTURE AND THE ROAD (60-75 min)

Leaving Stonefall

The party gathers supplies at the market, then heads west through Stonefall's half-finished gate. The frontier stretches before them: rolling grasslands dotted with ruins, old farmsteads, and the skeletons of pre-invasion civilization.

Give them a moment: "*The gate creaks shut behind you. Stonefall's walls shrink as you walk. Ahead: nothing but grass, sky, and the distant silhouette of broken structures. Somewhere out there is a facility that FX is afraid of. A symbol that three of you recognize from your pasts. A place that Aegon has seen in his dreams. The road is long. You have time to talk.*"

Day 1: The Waystation and the First Night (20 min)

Midday -- The Waystation: A small frontier outpost. A stable, a well, a single attendant who sells trail rations and water. Nailed to the wall: the **wanted poster** from Stonefall -- rough sketches of two party members. The attendant eyes them but says nothing. He doesn't want trouble.

Atmosphere beat: "*The attendant watches you as you fill your waterskins. He doesn't ask questions. But when you leave, you catch him staring at your backs. The poster stays on the wall.*"

Evening -- Camp: The first night under the stars. No encounters. Let the players talk. This is their first real chance to share stories around a campfire.

If the table goes quiet, use one of these:

- "*Aurora, the Broken Crown constellation is visible tonight, clearer than ever. It pulses faintly toward the west -- toward where you're heading.*"
- "*Balor, Khar'zul stirs for the first time since Stonefall. A whisper: 'The scent of old blood. We are going the right way.'*"
- "*Zan, the memory of the door with the symbol -- you keep seeing it when you close your eyes. The reinforced metal. The cold air from the gap beneath it. What was in that room?*"
- "*Bardolemeu, you're on watch. The frontier is silent. No wolves. No insects. Just wind. It feels like the land itself is waiting for something.*"

Day 2: The Abandoned Homestead (25 min)

Mid-afternoon. The party comes across a farmstead -- recently abandoned. The door is ajar. Pots still on the cold hearth. A half-eaten meal on the table. A child's doll on the floor.

The scene: Signs of a hasty departure, not an attack. No blood. No broken furniture. Just... left.

The strange detail: In the root cellar, arranged in a precise circle: a collection of shiny objects. A silver spoon. A chipped gemstone. Three copper coins. A broken dagger. All arranged neatly, facing the center of the circle.

What it is: A minor hoarding instinct manifestation. A child (or a desperate adult) felt the pull to collect and arrange shiny things before they fled. Too small to be dangerous. But strange.

Party reaction: They'll probably find it odd, maybe unsettling, then move on. They won't understand it. But they'll remember it months later when the pattern becomes clear.

Evening -- Second Camp: The party is now a full day into monster territory. The landscape has changed -- fewer signs of civilization, more ruins, overgrown roads.

- "*Kaelyn, your crystal heart has been warm since you crossed an invisible line about an hour ago. Not painful. Just... aware. Like something ahead is calling to it.*"
- "*Aegon, as you sit by the fire, you see a raven on a dead branch. It watches you. Then it flies west. The same direction you're heading.*"

Day 3: The Standing Stones (20 min)

Late morning. The party reaches a circle of standing stones -- ancient, weathered, covered in moss. They predate the Last Stand. Possibly predate the invasion.

The effect on the party:

- Aurora: Her constellations flicker. The Broken Crown pulses visibly.
- Kaelyn: Her crystal heart warms significantly. She feels a pull toward the center of the circle.
- Zan: His B-touched resonance stirs. His teleportation marks feel... closer. More accessible.
- Aegon: He recognizes this place from a vision he hasn't had yet. A flash of deja vu.
- Balor: The blade goes quiet. Completely silent. A rare moment of peace.
- Nyra: The Air Soul Crystal atop her staff glows faintly, resonating with the ancient magic.
- Bardolemeu: He feels the urge to play a note. The stone circle has perfect acoustics.

What the stones are: A ley line convergence point. Old magic. Older than the gods' deception. The party feels the residue of something vast and forgotten. No answers -- just atmosphere.

The arrival: Late afternoon on Day 3. The party crests a hill. Below them, in a shallow valley: **Site Gamma-7**.

"*The facility is smaller than you expected. One main building -- a low, rectangular structure of grey stone, partially collapsed. A broken tower at the northeast corner. A collapsed dome at the center. The*

frontier has been reclaiming it for years -- grass grows through cracks in the walls, vines cover the entrance. But the door is intact. And it's closed."

"*The sun is setting. You have maybe an hour of daylight left.*"

SESSION END. (Cliffhanger -- what do they do?)

PART 7: NPC QUICK REFERENCE

Old Man Rourke (Stonefall Shrine)

One-armed veteran. Chatty. Kind. Fierce in his youth -- now content to tend the shrine and greet travelers.

Grent and Marta (Safe House Guards)

Grent	Human, scarred, silent. Nods instead of speaking.
Mertha	Half-elf, talkative, curious about the party. "*You're the ones who did the job on the floating island, right? Heard it was clean.*"

The Waystation Attendant

Names unknown. Says little. Eyes the party with quiet suspicion.

PART 9: COMBAT (None Planned)

Session 1 has zero planned combat. All tension is atmospheric:

- Wanted posters
- The mystery of the symbol
- Frontier eeriness
- The standing stones
- The cliffhanger arrival

If players pick a fight, handle it improv. But the session is designed as a **social and exploration session** -- establishing relationships, planting mysteries, setting the tone for the campaign.

ROAD ENCOUNTERS (Single d12 Table)

For each day of travel, roll a d12 to see what the party encounters. If a result repeats between days, roll again -- or pick something that fits the current terrain. Each entry is designed to work on any of the 3 travel days. Adjust terrain descriptions to match where they are (farmlands, frontier, or the barren approach to Gamma-7).

Note: The party will also encounter 3 fixed story beats on the road -- the Waystation (Day 1), the Abandoned Homestead (Day 2), and the Standing Stones (Day 3) -- as described in Part 6. These happen regardless of the random roll.

d12	Encounter	Type
1	**Strange Lights.** At night, distant lights flicker on the horizon -- pale blue, pulsing, moving in patterns that feel intentional. They are miles away. No sound. No trail to follow. Aurora's constellations pulse in sync. If watched long enough, the lights vanish one by one, as if extinguished. No combat. No loot. Just a mystery to carry forward.	Atmosphere
2	**Blocked Path.** The road is blocked -- a fallen tree, a rockslide, a washed-out bridge. The party must choose: clear it (Strength check, 30 min), go around (Survival check to navigate, 1 hour, chance of getting slightly lost), or turn back and find another route (adds half a day). No right answer -- just a choice that makes the journey feel real.	Neutral
3	**Old Battlefield.** The remnants of a skirmish -- overgrown trenches, rusted weapons, bleached bones half-sunk in the mud. A pre-invasion Last Stand engagement. 2d10 sp can be scavenged from the muck. A rusted helmet with a bullet hole. A child's letter, never sent, still legible in a dead soldier's pouch. A moment of silence for the forgotten dead.	Atmosphere
4	**Traveling Merchant.** A lone trader with a mule-drawn cart, heading the opposite direction. Sells basic supplies (rations, water, rope) at standard prices. Shares rumors freely: strange lights in the frontier, monsters acting oddly, increased activity near old ruins. Won't linger -- wants to reach town before dark.	Positive

5	**Wolf Pack.** 3-4 wolves, drawn by the scent of food or the party's fire. Attack at night if no watch is set. If the party takes precautions (fire, watch, dog), the wolves circle but don't engage. Kill them for pelts (worth 1d6 gp total) or drive them off. Stat block in Part 14.	Combat
6	**Healing Spring.** A small natural pool, clear water, fed by an underground mineral spring. Drinking restores 1 HP. Bathing restores 1d4 HP (one-time benefit). The water tastes of iron and leaves faint blue residue on the skin that fades by morning. A quiet moment of respite.	Positive
7	**Ruined Temple.** Pre-invasion. Roof gone. Vines claim the walls. Altar cracked and weathered. The dedication plaque is worn illegible. Aurora's constellations flicker -- this place was never consecrated to a real god. Aegon senses nothing from his patron. This temple was built for a lie. No loot. Just a reminder that the world is not what the churches say.	Atmosphere
8	**Hermit's Hut.** A small cabin tucked against a hillside. An old woman (or man) lives alone. Offers shelter, a hot meal, and news from the frontier in exchange for stories from the east. Speaks of strange changes: "The wolves are gathering. Not for hunting -- for something else. And the old ruin to the west... sometimes there are lights at night." No combat. No loot. Just a human moment.	Positive
9	**Spider Nest.** The road passes through a rocky crevice or ruined structure. 4-5 giant wolf spiders have strung webs across the path (Perception DC 14 to spot). If the party walks in, combat. If they clear the nest, they find 1d10 gp + a pouch of salt (worth 5 gp to a frontier trader). Stat block in Part 14.	Combat
10	**Abandoned Camp.** A recent campsite -- cold ashes, kicked-over gear, a torn bedroll abandoned in haste. Half-buried in the dirt: a singed journal page. Shaky handwriting: "*Found the facility. The door was open. We should not have gone inside. Something is still in there.*" No	Story

	other loot. But the party knows: someone went before them. Not everyone came back.	
11	**Crystal Fragment.** A small shard of arcane-reactive crystal, half-buried in the dirt. Not as pure as the ones from the heist -- but unmistakably the same type. It hums faintly when held. Aurora's hidden constellations pulse in recognition. Kaelyn's crystal heart warms. Zan feels his B-touched resonance stir. A sign they are getting closer.	Story
12	**The Raven.** A single raven appears. It follows the party for an hour, perching on dead trees and fence posts, watching. If anyone speaks to it (Speak with Animals or similar), it cocks its head and says: "*The door is closed. It will not open for you.*" Then it flies west -- toward the facility. No combat. No loot. Just a portent.	Atmosphere

Note on pacing: Roll once per day (3 rolls total, plus the 3 fixed story beats = 6 encounters across 3 days). Re-roll duplicates. Adjust terrain descriptions to match where they are on the journey.

PART 11: RANDOM LOOT

A simple d8 table for when the party searches a location. Roll once per location. For special locations (like the standing stones), add a +1 bonus to the roll or let them roll twice and pick.

d8 Point of Interest Loot Table

d8	Find
1	**Nothing.** The place was picked clean long ago.
2	**Useless trinket.** A child's clay doll, a rusted belt buckle, a cracked clay pipe. Flavor only.
3	**Old coin.** 1d6 gp + 2d10 sp from before the invasion. The coins have a king's face no one recognizes.
4	**Useful gear.** A coil of hempen rope (50 ft), a full waterskin, or a hunting knife. Practical.
5	**Pre-invasion journal page.** Torn from a book. Handwritten. Describes daily life -- farming, market day, a child's birth. A mundane slice of life from before the Abominable End. No plot relevance. Just humanizing.
6	**Small gemstone.** Worth 10 gp. Chipped but viable. A frontier trader would buy it.

7	**Vial of holy water.** Still sealed. Blessed by a priest of Aurelius. Useful against undead and fiends.
8	**Strange object.** A small crystal shard -- not magical, but it hums faintly when held near large amounts of B essence. No immediate use. But if they keep it, it will glow when they approach Gamma-7.

PART 12: STONEFALL SHOPPING

Available at the **General Store** (run by Bram Hedderson, human male, middle-aged, flour on his apron). Prices include a 25% frontier markup compared to PHB standard.

Weapons & Ammo

Item	Price
Sling bullets (20)	2 cp
Arrows (20)	1 gp
Crossbow bolts (20)	1 gp 5 sp
Simple weapon (any)	PHB price + 25%
Martial weapon (any)	PHB price + 25%

Adventuring Gear

Item	Price
Backpack	2 gp
Bedroll	1 gp 5 sp
Blanket	5 sp
Candles (10)	5 cp
Crowbar	2 gp
Flint and steel	1 gp

Hempen rope (50 ft)	1 gp 5 sp
Hunting trap	5 gp
Lantern (hooded)	5 gp
Oil (flask)	1 sp
Rations (1 day)	1 gp
Signal whistle	5 cp
Torches (10)	1 sp
Waterskin	2 sp
Healer's Kit (10 uses)	5 gp

Tools & Kits

Item	Price
Climber's kit	25 gp
Disguise kit	25 gp
Herbalism kit	5 gp
Thieves' tools	25 gp
Mess kit	2 sp
Shovel	2 gp
Tent (2-person)	4 gp
Tent (4-person)	8 gp

Provisions

Item	Price
Dried meat (1 lb)	1 gp
Hard cheese (wheel)	5 sp
Bread (loaf)	5 cp
Ale (gallon)	4 sp
Wine (bottle)	2 gp
Waterskin (full)	2 sp

NOT Available in Stonefall

- Plate armor (no smith skilled enough -- nearest is Emberforge, weeks away)
- Spell scrolls (no resident mage)
- Magic items (none for sale -- this is a frontier town)
- Poison (not openly sold -- might be available through underworld contacts)

PART 13: FX'S PROVISIONS (Detailed)

FX provides the following when the party accepts the mission:

Consumables

Item	Qty	Notes
Trail rations	35 person-days	Dried meat, hardtack, dried fruit. Enough for 7 people for 5 days.
Waterskins (full)	7	One per person.
Potion of Healing	3	Standard: 2d4+2 HP. In small clay flasks tied with twine.
Antitoxin	1	Vial. Grants advantage on poison saving throws for 1 hour.

Gear

Item	Qty	Notes
Torches	10	Standard, 1 hour each.
Tinderbox	1	Shared. Flint + steel + dry tinder.
Bedrolls	7	Basic canvas and wool.
Tent (4-person)	2	Canvas, stitched, waxed.
Hempen rope (50 ft)	1	50 ft, braided.
Signal whistle	1	For emergencies. Loud.
Map case (leather)	1	Contains the hand-drawn map to Gamma-7.

Special

Item	Qty	Notes
Sending Stone	1 pair	FX keeps one, party takes one. Single-word activation. One use only, then inert. FX: "*Only if you find something that needs me to know NOW. Not for social calls.*"

FX's Instructions

"*The map is crude but accurate. Three days west, past the old waystation, past a burned-out farmstead. You'll know you're close when you see standing stones on a ridge. The facility is in the valley below. I want records, equipment, anything with that symbol. Bring it back. Don't die.*"

PART 14: WILDERNESS ENCOUNTERS (Stat Blocks)

Two simple encounters for the road. Use one, both, or neither. Adjust number of creatures based on party size (7 players -- you can use the higher end).

Encounter 1: Frontier Wolf Pack

A pack of wolves drawn by the scent of food or the party's fire. These are not hoarding-instinct monsters -- just hungry predators.

Use on: Night 2, if the party didn't set a watch, or as a daytime encounter if they wander into wolf territory.

Number: 3-4 wolves. For a party of 7 at level 2-3, 3 wolves is easy; 4 is a mild challenge (action economy makes numbers count).

Wolf (Medium beast, unaligned)

Stat	Value
AC	13 (natural armor)
HP	11 (2d8+2)
Speed	40 ft
STR	12 (+1)
DEX	15 (+2)
CON	12 (+1)
INT	3 (-4)
WIS	12 (+1)
CHA	6 (-2)

Feature	Description
Keen Hearing and Smell	Advantage on Wisdom (Perception) checks that rely on hearing or smell.
Pack Tactics	The wolf has advantage on attack rolls against a creature if at least one of the wolf's allies is within 5 ft of the creature and the ally isn't incapacitated.

Actions:

Attack	To Hit	Damage

Bite	+4	2d4+2 piercing damage. If the target is a creature, it must succeed on a DC 11 Strength saving throw or be knocked prone.

Encounter 2: Giant Wolf Spiders

The party disturbs a nest of giant wolf spiders in a ruined structure or along a forested section of the road. More unsettling than the wolves -- these are ambush predators.

Use on: Day 2 or 3, when the party investigates a ruined building or passes through a rocky area with crevices.

Number: 4-5 giant wolf spiders. Their low HP means they drop fast, but the poison makes them scary.

Giant Wolf Spider (Medium beast, unaligned)

Stat	Value
AC	13
HP	11 (2d8+2)
Speed	40 ft, climb 40 ft
STR	12 (+1)
DEX	16 (+3)
CON	13 (+1)
INT	3 (-4)
WIS	12 (+1)
CHA	4 (-3)

Feature	Description
Spider Climb	The spider can climb difficult surfaces, including upside down on ceilings, without needing to make an ability check.
Web Sense	While in contact with a web, the spider knows the exact location of any other creature in contact with the same web.

Web Walker	The spider ignores movement restrictions caused by webbing.

Actions:

Attack	To Hit	Damage
Bite	+3	1d6+1 piercing damage. The target must make a DC 11 Constitution saving throw, taking 2d6 poison damage on a failed save, or half as much damage on a successful one. If the poison damage reduces the target to 0 HP, the target is stable but poisoned for 1 hour, even after regaining HP.

Why these encounters work:

- **Wolves:** Simple, classic, teaches the party to set watches. Pack Tactics makes them more dangerous than their CR suggests.
- **Giant Wolf Spiders:** Weirder, more memorable. The poison creates tension without being lethal. Web climbing means they can come from above -- keeps players on edge.

PART 15: SESSION STRUCTURE (Revised for 4 Hours)

Phase	Scene	Content	Time
1	Arrival and Settling In	Safe house social time. Party interactions. Conversation starters.	30-40 min
2	Stonefall Exploration (optional)	Market square (wanted poster, town crier). Shrine. Tavern. General store.	20-30 min
3	FX's Briefing	Symbol reveal. The three private tells trigger. Mystery established.	15-20 min
4	Nyra Arrives	Two-curve mark. Connection established.	10 min
5	Aegon Arrives	Vision of Gamma-7. Party assembled.	10 min
6	The Decision	Party accepts the mission. FX hands over provisions.	15-20 min
7	Day 1 -- The Road	Waystation (wanted poster). First campfire RP.	20 min

8	Day 2 -- The Road	Abandoned homestead (hoarding hint). Optional: wolf or spider encounter.	25-35 min
9	Day 3 -- The Road	Standing stones (ley line convergence). Arrival at Gamma-7.	20 min
10	Cliffhanger	"The door is intact. And it's closed. What do you do?"	5 min

Estimated total: ~170-210 minutes of content + roleplay tangents, player chatter, and breaks = **4 hours comfortably**.